

Doing Good

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Introduction

Ephesians 2:10 states, “For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.” God is intrinsically good, and we are God’s good works who made like Him to do good on His behalf. The one who was the perfect representation of Him (Hebrews 1:3), Jesus Christ, went about doing good (Acts 10:38), living as one who had been sent out. Speaking of us, Jesus taught that every good tree brings forth good fruit (Matthew 7:17).

This is our purpose while we are still living: to do good.

From the Greek¹, the meaning of doing good includes to do right, to bestow benefits, to help, to do someone a favor, to be philanthropic, to make beautiful or excellent, to do well, to make well.

Since God has created us to do good works, we should not only do good at every opportunity, but we should also position ourselves to do more good, and we should influence those we can to be good and do good as well.

¹ The definition considers the words for good in the New Testament: agathopoieō, G15; agathos, G18; euergeteō, G2109; kalos, G2570; kalōs, G2573.

Our Position with God

How do we position ourselves with God to not only do good but to do the most good?

Many of us don't concern ourselves with doing much good because we are too concerned with making our own lives good. We put our own interests above those of Jesus Christ (Philippians 2:21). For those of us interested in doing good, too many of us who try to do good try to do it in our own strength and ability, and so the good we do is limited.

We cannot be good and truly do good without being connected to God as He designed us to be connected. Jesus said that "No one is good except God alone" (Mark 10:18).

If we are going to be connected to God in new life, we must hate our old life in the world enough to want to die to it (John 12:24-25). Too many of us like our life in the world. Too many of us like some sin. We attempt to grab onto God with one hand for Him to raise us up, meanwhile keeping on hand on our old life in the world – or really holding onto the devil with one hand. Following God does not work that way. We end up double-minded (James 1:8, 4:8), remaining infants in Christ who either do no good or not much good in God's eyes.

To die, we need to fully identify with Christ in His crucifixion and fully cooperate with the Spirit of God to renew our mind to the word of God. To fully identify with Christ in His crucifixion is to daily confess, as the Apostle Paul did, "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live..." (Galatians 2:20). Meanwhile, to renew our minds to the word of God (Romans 12:2), we must daily confess His word as the truth until we not only believe it but it also dwells richly in us (Colossians 3:16) and we are obedient to do all of it (James 1:22). As disciples, we must put God's word into practice; we must develop a pattern of obedience to God's word, or we do not love God as He has required us to love Him. As disciples, we resolve to no longer be led by the world's system, by self interest, by fear, by desire, or any by emotion of our own soul. Instead, cooperating with God, we develop single-minded focus (Matthew 6:22) on God's word, which is His will, not getting entangled in the affairs of life (Mark 4:19, 2 Timothy 2:4). Identifying with our righteousness and victory in Christ through His resurrection and ascension, we are to steadfastly resist the devil and overcome the world until they have no hold on us. This is to die to our old self and life in the world. This is the way of repentance, and it's time to get serious about it.

Identifying ourselves with God's word and His word made flesh, Jesus Christ, in this way, we can then confess with the Apostle Paul, "It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me" (Galatians 2:20). It is then that we abide in Christ as the vine (John 15:4), connected to God's source of life and His nature of good. It is only then that we will be led by His Spirit (Romans 8:14) to be zealous for good works (Titus 2:14). This is God's own good nature.

If we want to bear good fruit and much of it, we must allow the imperishable word of God (1 Peter 1:23) to do what it was designed to do in us: kill sin, make us new, grow us up to maturity in God's own character and nature, and channel God's goodness.

This is how you position yourself with God to be a channel of His goodness to those He has already placed around you in your part of His world. For more on discipleship, see my books Word Prompts and Rooms, available at www.jason.church.

Positioning Family

As followers of Jesus Christ, we are to seek to turn all situations into glory to God the Father, even as Jesus did. This includes situations with family.

How do we position ourselves and God within our family to do the most good? How do we best position our family members to do good?

What's good for us is good for them: close connection to God through Jesus Christ and the maturity and blessings that come through discipleship.

Spouse. Married Christians are a team designed by God from the very beginning of His creation to be good and to do good in the world. They are meant to work together with each other, with God, and with God's church. Young spouses or spouses young in the Lord need to grow up in maturity together, if they are going to be used by God to do good. For more on this, see my book [#married](#).

Children. While we may bless any family member, we have an especially large effect on our children. It's the totality of our lifestyle and our engagement with them that matters (Deuteronomy 6:4-9). They see our character and how it affects what we regularly say and do. Especially when they are young and, often, if we do it well, continuing into early adulthood, we have a chance to disciple them to know God's word and to become doers of God's word. While they benefit from hearing us teach them the gospel, they benefit much more from seeing us live it out. When they see us doing God's word, they will also come to do it. When they see us stretch and step out in faith, they learn to live by faith. When they become doers of God's word, they do good. So mightily grows God's word and prevails in our family (Acts 19:20).

Extended family. As adults, our extended family includes those we no longer live or talk with frequently (such that we could have discipling relationships) but whom we see and/or talk to with some frequency. We do good to them by exposing them to the source of all good. Our job is to be kingdom ambassadors who represent Jesus Christ to them, preaching and demonstrating the kingdom of God. Our job is to plant the seed of the word of God and to water it when we have occasion to do so. We should bless them with our words, believing and speaking good about them and for them. We should pray for them to be set free from sin and quickened by God. It is God who saves and gives growth. This is how we cooperate with Him.

Positioning God's church

Today in America, many look to their churches to meet their spiritual needs and the spiritual needs of their families, most expecting to receive what is needed through connecting at their churches a few hours a week, then leaving to return to their secular lives.

This is a completely wrong view of God's church. The church is not mainly there as our supply that enables us to go our separate ways and pursue our own interests. Our direct connection to God Himself is our supply (1 Corinthians 6:17, Philippians 4:19). While Jesus is enthroned at the right hand of our Father, we as His church are His new, functioning body in the world, living to carry out God's will on earth as it is in heaven. We are connected to it in order to team together to function as His body that lives in and moves into the world, continuing His ministry of going about and doing good, yet on a much greater scale than what Jesus Himself could accomplish as one man in the world.

As such, you are to position yourself with your church to do good to those within it, and you are to position your church to do good in the world. It is written:

"So then, as we have opportunity, let us do good to everyone, and especially to those who are of the household of faith."

Galatians 6:10 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/gal.6.10.ESV>

As followers of Jesus Christ, our interest should be to cooperate with God and each other to do the most good. On our own with God, we can accomplish much, yet as part of His body of other like-minded believers, we can accomplish much more. Our main interest should be to do all of God's will that is recorded in His word.

As members of God's church, we are all ministers working together with God to do the good He has prepared in advance for us to do. As ministers, we are not only to do good to those in the household of faith, meeting their needs, but we are to equip them to be ministers who do good, able to meet the needs of God's church and the world. This equipping happens through making disciples, or those who live as practitioners of God's word. Meanwhile, as we are obedient to get up, get out in the world, and use what God gave us, the Holy Spirit further equips us with His fullness, giving some of us today to be apostles, building up His church; some today to be evangelists, making new converts; some today to be shepherds and teachers, making disciples out of converts (Ephesians 4:7-16); some today having *revelation* from the Spirit by way of words of wisdom, knowledge, and discernment of spirits; some today having power from the Spirit by way of faith, healing, and working miracles; some today having *inspiration* from the Spirit by way of prophecy, the speaking of God's word; speaking in diverse tongues of men and angels; and interpretation of those tongues (1 Corinthians 12:4-11,27-31).

Working together with God, we are fully equipped as Jesus Christ Himself to minister to the world around us! After all, God's Spirit that abides now in us puts the name "Christ" in Jesus Christ. Working together with God, He will fulfill our every resolve for good and every work of faith by His power, so that the name of our Lord Jesus may be glorified (2 Thessalonians 1:11).

Neighborhood

God has placed us into neighborhoods in the world, and we are to position ourselves in our neighborhoods to do good to our neighbors. This is not something meant as much for individuals as it is meant for our church families, including members of our family who are part of God's church.

Our first work on behalf of our neighbors, unbelieving or believing, should be prayer in Jesus' name. You represent Jesus; pray in faith, expecting what you pray to come to pass. Pray for laborers to be sent to reach them and meet their needs, for one person can only do so much. This is why Jesus called disciples; it's why He gave the Holy Spirit, saying it's better that He went away. Pray for their complete freedom from the bondage of the enemy. Pray that those needing healing would be healed, the kingdom coming near to them. Pray that they would see the light of the gospel and come to repentance. Pray that the word of God would take root in them and grow to maturity. Speak good about them, expecting it to come to pass; this is to bless them. Pray for them to experience the fullness of God's life and love. Pray for discipling relationships with them. By way of Bible study, prayer, and training, become established in your faith to the extent that you are ready to step out as a minister of Jesus Christ.

God's model for interaction with neighbors is given in Christ's commands to His disciples. Go to their houses with another like minded believer. Knock on their doors. If they answer, greet them. Introduce yourself, and let your peace come upon them. Remain with them as they are willing. Heal the sick among them, saying to them, "The kingdom has come near to you." Freely give. Tell them about God's gift in Jesus Christ and His call to repentance and following Christ. If they are willing, invite them to be baptized and into discipleship. You may baptize them. If they are not receptive, let your peace return to you and leave.

All Christians need discipling, especially new ones. You may disciple your neighbors by inviting them to your home, inviting them out, and inviting them to church. Discipleship is about relationship. While Jesus was with His disciples, it was about forsaking all to follow Him, who was filled as a man with the fullness of God's Spirit, imitating His whole lifestyle. While Jesus was with them in Spirit, it was still about forsaking all to follow Him, becoming filled with the fullness of the Spirit, imitating His lifestyle. God's Spirit living in us, discipleship is an upward trajectory of coming to think as Jesus thinks, talk as He talks, and do what He does.

By way of those willing to be functioning members of His body, Jesus Christ is still about doing good by way of doing God's word, thereby fulfilling God's will to make things on earth as they are in heaven. Jesus Christ makes Himself **available**, speaks the truth **boldly**, is moved by **compassion**, and is **determined** to advance God's kingdom. (Note the a, b, c, d characteristics.) Christ in you, you are to proclaim, demonstrate (together with God), and establish the kingdom of God in your neighborhood. His kingdom is the rule of God, the government of God, the places where His will is done. By bringing His kingdom to the homes of your neighbors, you channel the word and the life of God to flow there, unleashing the riches of His grace in His kindness toward them. Let's get out there and love our neighbors as ourselves.

Workplace

Every workplace has a system to try to align you to be productive in doing what they want you to do. It testifies to the values of the organization. You are evaluated according to this system that reflects their values every year.

With respect to work, we need to change our thinking such that we change our entire life there. The God we follow has different values and a completely different system. We are God's workmanship, sons and daughters of God, purchased away from Satan's claim on us by the blood of Jesus Christ, created in Christ Jesus unto good works. We are no longer part of the world's system or citizenry but instead part of the government and rule of God by way of His kingdom. We are citizens that carry out God's will to do good, to make things right on earth as they are in heaven. This is what it means to be in the world but not of it.

As sons and daughters of God, position yourself in your workplace to do the most good. Those we encounter in the workplace are neighbors as well. Some may even be enemies of God. Even so, God's word is quite clear. His character and nature is to be good and to be kind to all, seeking for them to come to repentance. He expects our character and nature to become aligned with His own. Our thoughts, words, and actions are to be continually for their good. We are to look at our coworkers, thinking about what Jesus Christ's redemption has made possible for them, should they come to repentance today, even as Saul came to repentance when Jesus appeared to Him, just as the criminal on the cross turned to faith in Jesus Christ on the day of their deaths. We are to represent Jesus Christ to our coworkers. We are to live as the word of God (become flesh) that most of them do not read.

This means you will not work according to the evaluation metrics of your workplace, nor seek to climb their ladder of success. Yet, being unselfish, you will seek the good of everyone in your organization. You will be honest, loving, patient, and always do what is right. You will be humble, looking for opportunities to lift others up. You will take opportunities to serve that don't restrict the good you can do outside of the time you are committed to work. You will not participate in speaking bad about others, but you will only speak good. You will not hide your love for God or your faith in God, but instead you will be known for speaking and doing so much good that you will be a torchbearer, a light on a hill, shining brightly to the whole organization. You will seek to be a channel of God's life, goodness, and blessing to them.

Look for opportunities to do good unto those at work in the ways that you are to do good to your neighbors and to your family. As you are able, look to establish systems and practices that ensure the right thing is done. Look to establish and build up the community at work. Look to establish God's church in those receptive within your workplace.

City/government

Even when Israel was captive in Babylon for seventy years, the Spirit of God told me through Jeremiah, “And seek the peace of the city whither I have cause you to be carried away captives, and pray unto the LORD for it: for in the peace thereof shall ye have peace” (Jeremiah 29:7, KJV). As God’s people, we are to cooperate with God to seek the peace, welfare, and completeness (shâlôm, H7965) of our city, no matter its allegiance or treatment of us. We are to position ourselves within our city to do good in the ways the Spirit of God loves to do good.

Upon the Apostle Peter’s confession of Jesus as the Christ, the Son of the living God, Jesus called the disciples of His church (ekklēsia, G1577) to cooperate with God to overcome evil with good in His only mention of the church in the gospels. Upon the rock of faith in Peter’s confession of Jesus as the Christ, Jesus said, “on this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven” (Matthew 16:18-19, ESV).

God’s people are those who are called out into assembly to enforce Jesus Christ’s victory of the spiritual war against the gates of hell, thereby channeling peace, welfare, and wholeness to their cities. The Greek word ekklēsia refers to those called out into assembly. In the day of its use, the ekklēsia was a governing body of a city-state responsible for declaring war, military strategy and electing officials. The war against the goodness of God that troubles our cities has spiritual roots, as described in Revelation 12:7-12, because Satan and his angels were thrown down from heaven to earth in great wrath toward God’s image bearers. Yet, God has enabled us to enforce Christ’s victory over evil “by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of [our] testimony.”

God’s people are called out to come together to overcome evil with good in their cities, and so we should position ourselves to do good. We do good by boldly and openly preaching and demonstrating the gospel of the kingdom together to those in our cities, making the most of the blood that our Lamb shed at the whipping post and the cross. We are to make disciples of those willing to be called out with us; we are called out in Jesus’ name to join God in His victory of putting evil under foot in our cities, thereby expanding His kingdom. His kingdom is His government, His rule, the places where His will is done on earth as it is in heaven.

As God’s kingdom ekklēsia, our testimony consists of words spoken in faith that carry with them authority and ability to overcome all things associated with Satan and his associates, including sin, sickness, death. The Spirit of God abiding in us, Jesus has given our words spoken in faith the same weight as His words spoken in faith. With regard to any evil, we can bind (deō, G1210) it, forbid it, or declare it to be illicit. With regard to evil’s hold on any image bearer of God, we are able to loose (luō, G3089) them from it, setting them free from its captivity over them, as Jesus often demonstrated. To defeat evil, we are able to follow Christ’s example to claim “it is written,” repeat the word of God, and expect it to be done in our situation. This is the sword of the Spirit. With our words spoken in faith, we can tell any mountain in the way of God’s kingdom advancement and glory to move. Considering God’s glory, whatever we ask for in

prayer, believing that we have received it, it will be ours, if we will stand firm until it has become ours.

God is with us. Cooperating with the Holy Spirit of God and His power that abides in us, we are to go about our cities and counties doing good to everyone.

This different way of thinking, speaking, and acting as kingdom citizens has implications for the way we think about church (ekklēsia) and the way we spend our days putting God's word into practice as the disciples of Christ, the practitioners of His word. It has implications for our neighborhoods, schools, hospitals, prisons, and social care. It has implications for the way we serve those of our cities within nonprofits. It has implications for the way we interact with and contribute to our city and county government. It has implications for how we should spend our attention, time, energy and money.

Are you a disciple? Are you a member of Christ's living body, His church (ekklēsia)?

Let's decide together that God's words for Christ's disciples are directed at us. Let's decide together to take up the responsibility that God has given to us as His church. Let's decide together to live as those who have been sent out.

New Testament commands related to doing good

Be kind of brotherly love one to another; Romans 12:10, Ephesians 4:32
Be given to hospitality; Romans 12:13
Be always abounding in God's work; 1 Corinthians 15:58
Be tenderhearted one to another; Ephesians 4:32
Be an example to believers in word, conversation, charity, spirit, faith and purity; 1 Timothy 4:12
Be gentle to all people; 2 Timothy 2:24
Be careful to maintain good works; Titus 3:8,14; Matthew 5:16
Be doers of the Word; James 1:22
Be courteous; 1 Peter 3:8
Be clothed with humility; 1 Peter 5:5
Bless those who curse you; Matthew 5:44, Luke 6:28
Bless your persecutors; Romans 12:14
Comfort one another (fellow Christians); 1 Thessalonians 4:18, 5:11
Comfort the feeble-minded; 1 Thessalonians 5:14
Honor others; Romans 12:10, 1 Peter 2:17
Honor widows; 1 Timothy 5:13
Continue in love; John 15:9
Feed your enemies; Romans 12:20
Feed God's lambs and sheep; John 21:15-17
Feed the flock of God; 1 Peter 5:2
Feed the church; Acts 20:28
Do go to those who hate you; Matthew 5:44, Luke 6:27
Do to others what you expect of them; Matthew 7:12, Luke 6:31
Do good; Luke 6:35, Romans 13:3
Do all to God's glory; 1 Corinthians 10:31, Colossians 3:17,23
Do the work of an evangelist; 2 Timothy 4:5
Follow good; 1 Thessalonians 5:15, 3 John 1:11
Give; Luke 6:38
Give to him that asks; Matthew 5:42, Luke 6:30
Give to needy saints; Romans 12:13
Give glory to God; Revelations 14:7
Give freely; Matthew 10:8, 2 Corinthians 9:6
Give good measure; Luke 6:38
Give as God has prospered; 1 Corinthians 16:2
Give willingly; 2 Corinthians 8:12
Give with purpose; 2 Corinthians 9:7
Give cheerfully; 2 Corinthians 9:7
Keep the good entrusted you; 2 Timothy 1:14
Go teach; Matthew 28:19-20
Go preach; Mark 16:15
Have compassion; 1 Peter 3:8, Jude 1:22
Have fervent love; 1 Peter 4:8

Hold forth the Word of life; Philippians 2:16
Hold fast to the good; 1 Thessalonians 5:21
Let your light shine; Matthew 5:16, Luke 12:35
Let your enemy have your cloak; Matthew 5:40, Luke 6:29
Let him share with the needy; Luke 3:11
Let your love be genuine; Romans 12:9
Let everyone take heed how he builds upon Christ; 1 Corinthians 3:10
Let all things be done to edifying; 1 Corinthians 14:26
Let the word dwell in you; Colossians 3:16
Let speech be with grace; Colossians 4:6
Let everyone give as God prospers them; 1 Corinthians 16:2
Let all things be done in love; 1 Corinthians 16:14
Let husbands love their wives; Ephesians 5:25,28,33; Colossians 3:19; 1 Peter 3:7
Let wives reverence their husbands; Ephesians 5:33
Let your conversation (behavior) be becoming of the gospel; Philippians 1:27
Let each esteem other better than himself; Philippians 2:3
Let brotherly love continue; Hebrews 13:1
Let elders pray for the sick, anointing with oil; James 5:14-15, Mark 6:13
Let everyone shun evil, do good, seek peace and pursue it; 1 Peter 3:11
Let us follow things that edify; Romans 14:19
Let us please neighbor for good; Romans 15:2-3
Let us be sincere; 1 Corinthians 5:8
Let us walk in the Spirit; Galatians 5:25
Let us not be weary in well doing; Galatians 6:9
Let us do good to all people; Galatians 6:10
Let us do good especially to fellow Christians; Galatians 6:10
Let us come boldly to the throne of grace; Hebrews 4:16, 10:19-23
Let us provoke one another to love and good works; Hebrews 10:24
Let us exhort one another; Hebrews 10:25
Let us love one another; 1 John 4:7,11
Love your enemies; Matthew 5:44, Luke 6:27,35
Love your fellow Christians; John 13:14, 15:12,17; Galatians 5:14; 1 Peter 2:17; 1 John 3:23; 2 John 1:5
Love the brotherhood; 1 Peter 2:17
Love your brother; 1 John 4:21
Love fervently; 1 Peter 2:22
Love with a pure heart; 1 Peter 2:22
Love each other as brethren; 1 Peter 3:8
Pray for your persecutors; Matthew 5:44, Luke 6:28
Pray for laborers; Matthew 9:38, Luke 10:2
Pray for one another; James 5:16
Put on the bowels of mercy; Colossians 3:12
Put on kindness; Colossians 3:12
Put on love; Colossians 3:14

Seek to edify the church; 1 Corinthians 14:12
Submit one to another; Ephesians 5:21
Take oversight of the flock willingly; 1 Peter 5:2
Take heed to the flock of God; Acts 20:28
Take heed to your ministry; Colossians 4:17
Thou shalt love neighbors as yourself; Matthew 5:43, 19:19, 22:39; Mark 12:31; Luke 10:27;
Romans 13:9; Galatians 5:14
Walk in love; Ephesians 5:2
Bear one another's burdens; Galatians 6:2
Bring your children up in the Lord; Ephesians 6:4
Call the poor to your feast; Luke 14:13
Children, obey your parents; Ephesians 6:1, Colossians 3:20
Cleanse the lepers; Matthew 10:8
Cleave to good; Romans 12:9
Commit the truth to faithful teachers; 2 Timothy 2:2
Earnestly contend for the faith; Jude 1:3
Edify one another; 1 Thessalonians 5:11
Enter the straight (narrow) gate; Matthew 7:13, Luke 13:24
Exercise in godliness; 1 Timothy 4:7-8
Exhort one another daily; Hebrews 3:13
Fight the good fight of faith; 1 Timothy 6:12
Forbear one another; Colossians 3:13
Forgive 490 times; Matthew 18:22
Forgive; Matthew 11:25-26, Luke 6:37, Ephesians 4:32, Colossians 3:13
Give your enemy a drink of water; Romans 12:20
Have no respect of persons (partiality, prejudice); 1 Timothy 5:21
Heal the sick; Matthew 10:8, Luke 10:9
Help propagate truth; 3 John 1:8
Husbands, love your wives; Ephesians 5:25,28; Colossians 3:19; 1 Peter 3:7
Lend, hoping for nothing back; Luke 6:35
Make full proof of your ministry; 2 Timothy 4:5
Make straight paths; Hebrews 12:13
Be good to servants; Ephesians 5:9, Colossians 4:1
Minister as good stewards; 1 Peter 4:10
Neglect not spiritual gifts; 1 Timothy 4:14, 2 Timothy 1:6
Offer the other cheek; Matthew 5:39, Luke 6:29
Overcome evil with good; Romans 12:21
Pay just dues; Romans 13:7
Preach; Matthew 10:7,27, Mark 16:15, 2 Timothy 4:2
Provide things honestly; Romans 12:17
Raise the dead; Matthew 10:8
Receive (accept) weak brethren; Romans 14:1
Receive one another; Romans 15:7
Redeem the time; Ephesians 5:16, Colossians 4:5

Restore backsliders in meekness, considering your own life; Galatians 6:1
Sell to help the needy; Luke 12:33
Show charity to other ministers; Luke 9:49-50
Speak truth; Ephesians 4:25
Speak sound doctrine; Titus 2:1
Support the weak; 1 Thessalonians 5:14
Tarry one for another; 1 Corinthians 11:33
Teach one another; Colossians 3:16
Use hospitality without grudging; 1 Peter 4:9
Weep with others; Romans 12:15
Work with your own hands; 1 Thessalonians 4:11